

How I Came to Establish a Non-Community

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 25:00

I thought I would preface this talk by telling you, you're all going to be very disappointed. When Simon emailed me and said we'd like you to do a presentation on your community, I said, I don't have a community. And then very foolishly I said, I can tell you how to establish a non-community. So this was way back, and I tested him a little bit before this conference. He said, you really want me to talk about how I ended up in a place without a community? I said, sure. So here I am, explaining to you how I got to a place without a community. Now the question is, do you want me to carry on? Thank you.

Well, what it is, it's a story. So if you just sit back and enjoy a story, then it works. You don't expect to learn anything. Well, that's your story. That's my story.

So in '98, I returned from Sri Lanka not feeling very well, and I decided to spend the rest of the rainy season, which is our summertime, in a place which was full of good air and a lively and supportive atmosphere, which was London. I got a contract going with the chief monk at the Sri Lankan Buddhist Vihara in London. And he very kindly gave me a room at the back end of the monastery where I could just carry on. And by the end of that, I hoped that there'd be some clarification as to whether I wanted to go back to the East or stay in the West.

Unfortunately during that time the monk who was teaching the meditation, a young Asian monk, decided on receiving British nationality to leave and get married. So, not an uncommon occurrence. They asked me, I said, well, you know, I really don't want to, but you have to. So I began teaching, and to my surprise, there was some growth in the audience and all that.

By the end of a year or so, I'd come to realize that, A, I didn't want to go back to the East. My time there was over. And B, if I wanted to stay in the West, there was no way I would get the support I needed to live the life I wanted to, which was a solitudinous life at the end of a valley. And I would have to earn my living. And to do that, you have to teach. So I reluctantly decided to teach and I went off on a long retreat at one of my teacher's places, Sayadaw Upandita—that's the Burmese connection. The meditation I teach is Burmese, the Mahāsi Sayadaw tradition. And I spent the season there.

Now, during that, just before I left, a venerable, I can't remember his name now, the chief monk who died at London—anyway, he died. Let's just say he died. Seemingly, along with his name. So he had got very upset with me. I'll tell you why later. So I wrote this letter explaining my position. And when I got to the monastery, I began meditating, again in the very lugubrious and wonderful air of Rangoon. And I asked people not to give me any letters or anything like that until the end of the retreat. A letter was handed to me, and the abbot said, in so many words, I'm tremendously disgusted with you. When you come back,

you can stay for two nights. That was it.

I'm looking at this letter thinking, I've been thrown out of house and home. So I get back, and of course I have a chat with him, and everything is reconciled. But I realised that I didn't have a power over my own life, that he could just kick me out when he felt like it. Now the reason he took that position was very simple. Can you imagine setting up a business and somebody comes along who comes along as a helper or at least begins to help you. On the quiet, without you really knowing, he's setting up his own business with your clients. This is what I was doing. I was setting up my own little sangha from the sangha that he had himself established at the Vihara. So he's very upset. I can understand it.

So I decided then to leave the Vihara. At that point, I had the help of a young Dutchman who was doing a PhD in London, Mattes—we know him, Mattes. And that was a time when websites were just about coming in, 2000, 2001. So we set up a website and we put to people this vision. And the vision was of a Mahāsi meditation centre right there in the middle of London, servicing London, which would not only offer evening classes, but the ability to do long retreats, just like in Rangoon. And my little mantra was, where there's suffering, there's the end of it. And it was here, it was in London. So why go anywhere else?

So we collected this money and there now was a series of blunders which led to this catastrophe. The first one was that where were we going to have this centre? So we decided that it was going to be in the north because in the north there were two Sri Lankan women who were great supporters who wanted us to go there. I didn't want to stay in the west of London because that would undermine, again, this relationship I had with the abbot.

So we moved to the north and we moved into an area that was full of Greek Cypriots and Jews. So there was not a single ability to have any local people who would come to the meeting. That was the first blunder.

The second blunder was the opening ceremony. I realised that I didn't want to disturb the neighbours. I knew that round about thirty people would come from the west of London, but there was also a rather large local Sri Lankan community. So I decided to have two ceremonies. The first was the opening ceremony, which would just bless the property, and the second one would be the blessing ceremony of this particular lovely statue that the abbot gave me for this centre.

So the opening ceremony, all the English people came and with lots of food and it was all very grand, it was all very lovely. And when it came to the Sri Lankan opening centre, three people turned up. They were absolutely insulted that they'd not been invited to the opening. So I lost their support.

Then I opened up and said, you know, we're going to have classes here and weekend retreats. Well, it takes two hours to go from the west of London to the north. So nobody came. So there I am in splendid isolation in the north of London with 25,000 pounds, 30,000 euros to spend. And the rent is 1,200 euros a month. And I'm stuck there on my own, thinking, well, this is a catastrophe.

Then comes the third catastrophe, the third blunder. I began to advertise it in all the places around North London, and I had two young men who were ready to cycle everywhere and put these little notices up—meditation, etc. I'd given all the information to one of the persons who was then quite able on his computer, and he made this lovely sign, which I foolishly failed to check. After this wonderful spreading of all these notes, they gave me one, and I realised, A, it did not have an address. And B, the phone number was wrong.

The first meeting on Monday, one person came—the next door neighbour. On the second meeting Monday, zilch, nobody. And I said to Mattes, I said, look, I said, September, people organize their lives now. You know, they go to knitting clubs, violin lessons, whatever it is, they organize it in September for the autumn. And I said, if nothing happens by the end of this month, nothing's going to happen. So come the end of the month, nothing's happened, nothing's going to happen. So I said, look, we're going to have to close this place down.

Now I have to be thankful to the Sri Lankan community, because when I mentioned this to these two women, they really rallied the Sri Lankans to come and try and lift up this dying elephant. Anyway, we'd already paid this rent, so there's no point in leaving the place. So come the winter, I at least, one of the parts of the vision was realized where we had a retreat in that little house in the north of London for five of us. And through the Bodhisattva supermarket, Asda, we were able to get our food every week. And we did what I thought was an excellent retreat. Very quiet, very still. It was really quite wonderful.

But then, of course, there came the realization that I just couldn't go on. And that the whole thing had been an unmitigated disaster. So in that there, through the support of a close friend who'd been on retreat with me, he got in contact with somebody he knew, the Batchelors, whom some of you know, from Gaia House. And it was just at that point that Gaia House were short of a teacher, wanted a resident teacher. So I immediately accepted the offer and found myself invited to Gaia House and having arrived there realised they didn't want me.

I stayed there in this limbo place for four years. And it was after one year that I realised that there wasn't any future for me at Gaia House. For those of you who understand the metaphor, it was like being a Catholic priest amongst Quakers. Complete utter nonsense however I do look—however I have tremendous gratitude towards Gaia House. It's a really fabulous centre and they allowed me to run these long meditation retreats, eight week retreats which were well attended.

And it was there, that having realised I couldn't stay, that I began to think about again having another go at setting up a centre. Once burnt, well, you've got to burn yourself a bit more. So we set up a trust and whatnot, and off we went, and I almost made the same blunders again. Were it not that we just woke up at the right time. We found a place which was happily, somebody took it from us—they bid it higher. And then—that would have been a real blunder, frankly. And eventually we found a place which is on the border of England, in Wales, and easily accessible, fairly easily accessible. And that's where we established

ourselves.

Now, one decision I've made, two decisions I've made in this whole period of time, was, first of all, to try and maintain the Buddha Dhamma as it was being transmitted to me from the Mahāsi tradition especially, but also Sri Lankan, but specifically meditation-wise through the Mahāsi tradition. And not to throw the baby out with the bathwater, not to throw what's good about the tradition, to try and be a traditionalist without being conservative. And so I tried to maintain very simple forms, which was just taking refuges and precepts, and really centring the whole place upon meditation. The effectiveness, of course, is that it doesn't attract any Easterners. And therefore, whatever support there might have come from the East or from Easterners in Britain, it just doesn't come.

The second one was something that I had to come to grips with when I went to Gaia House. What happened to the teachers was that they were trained like I was. This is the *Vipassanā* teachers. You know, people like Christina Fellman and Christopher Titmuss and all those. They were trained like me by Eastern teachers who really demanded blood. You know, you were up at half past three, sit, walk, sit, walk, sit, walk, sit, walk, drop dead, ten o'clock. Back up again at half past three. I mean, it's really full on.

And what had happened over a period of time, the time that I was in Sri Lanka at the monastery, was that of course they had to come to grips with the reality that most people who were coming to meditate just couldn't handle that sort of form. So very slowly, it's put in a bad way, the meditation taught was becoming watered down. And I don't think that's fair. It's not watered down. It's simply presented in a way that's acceptable for people who really aren't at the level of this very hard practice. However, when I was there, it was quite obvious that there were a few people who were ready for that sort of practice.

So that was my second decision, was to maintain the heavy, hardcore practice of *Vipassanā* meditation in the Mahāsi tradition. But that necessarily meant a very small centre. I only take eight meditators and I don't have a long waiting list. I mean it is very small.

So I have this place in the middle of Wales with a very small intake and a growing sense that these people who are coming regularly—so that's the other thing which is a surprise to me. I have a return rate of something around 70%. Now, this is where I'm stuck at the moment, and this is where hopefully these talks about establishing community will be of help to me.

I can feel that something needs to be done to make this disparate community contact each other. They come from everywhere. They come from all parts of England, sometimes from other parts of Europe. But when they've got to know each other through the meditation experience, because I always bring the meditation down slowly at the end so there's plenty of time to talk and chat and get to know people, that some of them have made connections, made friendships and even visit each other. And somehow to let that grow either organically or to do something to aid that process.

But in my experience, what has happened is that I began teaching weekend retreats and then realized that

people wanted week-long. And then just before going back now to '99, I was offered a house in Yorkshire near Thirsk, very beautiful, where I ran my first ever ten week long retreat. And to my surprise, thirty people came. Not for the full time, but five or six of them actually stayed the full ten weeks. So there was this constant feeling by me of feeding back into the people who were working with me the opportunity to work for longer and deeper and deeper and deeper.

And it seems to me now that I'm at this place where unless something happens to connect these people and to create what Vajratara has so eloquently explained in her delivery there, unless I do that, then something's going to give. It'll either begin to evaporate or it'll either grow. That's my story.

So any of you who can help me in this little dilemma, I'll be very grateful. I'm sorry I haven't been able to say anything about creating community. Thank you.

I don't really appreciate your story. I love stories. Thank you. You can identify with a lot of it. And my question is the same. Can anyone give me any advice? I don't know what it is, but it does seem to be something to do with the right people come together at the right time. It goes or sometimes it's just not the time. It evaporates. It's not actually a component. That's the way it is. At least I can say that Satipaṇṇā has been a flash in the phenomenal universe.

Somebody told me there is a lack of places in Europe where one can do longer *vipassanā* retreats, so I would encourage you to go on. Thank you.

I just wondered, Bhante, whether you'd challenge the idea that you seem to have that it's you that need to do something. Oh, well, that's what I meant, whether to let it grow organically, whether to see what happens, rather than me all the time. Up until now, it's been me, me, me.

I'm struck by what Vajratara said about the importance of giving—you're talking about young people—the importance of giving young people the initiative, in other words, the autonomy. I mean, if you as a teacher can teach and the people who gather around you want to gather themselves into a sangha and see the advantage of that, you might help them see the advantage of it. But then you could leave them to do what they want to do in the way that they want to do it. Very dangerous.

Can I just add to that that I don't get anybody young. They're all over thirty-five. Or even worse.

I'd just like to make a comment what strikes me of how much joy was triggered through your story here.

How much laughter is coming around by somebody talking seemingly about one's own failures.

Yes. Schadenfreude. Schadenfreude. British humour. Terrible.

I was going to ask you about, because you said to me earlier that you didn't have one person living with you, and what about the opportunities to actually have people who might want to live a lifestyle with you?

Well, that's one of my problems. It's too small. I mean, when I've got the extra rooms put up, that would

really leave me with about twelve maximum. And a lot of it's to do with the size of the septic tank.

Laughter

To be honest about your situation is perfect. It's perfect. Get a small septic tank which gives the upper limit of what's possible. That's true. Let all the rest just happen. Just let people organise themselves.

I am at a similar point in my process up in the mountain, like forest, three room apartment. Why should I organise the sangha? Why? Let the sangha organise itself. Our task is just to give the Dhamma, and then what? Let them organise. We can encourage them to organise themselves. We are there. Let them do it. No need for bigger septic tanks. That is saving.

Thank you very much. If you ever have to find a source of funding, you can do it as a stand-up comedian.

Yes! Yes!

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